

Prompt is a no-nonsense way of finding out useful information, such as your computer's IP address, as well as running basic or even complex commands.

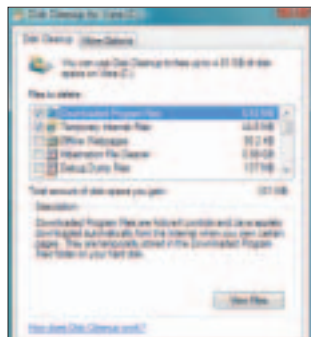
Dual-monitor backgrounds

Adding your own wallpaper is a great way to add a personal touch to Vista. But if you have two monitors, Vista's Display Properties tool will only let you replicate the image on both screens instead of providing the option of stretching it across the two. The end result is that a beautiful landscape scene, for example, turns into a nasty case of double vision.

Displayfusion is a free application that provides you with a collection of advanced Vista wallpaper options, including the ability to place separate images on each monitor or stretch a single image across both. To try it out, head to www.binaryfortress.com/displayfusion and download the Free edition. A Pro version is also available and offers a few more advanced tools, but most users will be more than happy with the free alternative.

Clean Desktop

If your Desktop wallpaper is truly a work of art, there's little point letting a bunch of ugly icons ruin it. To quickly remove all trace of your Desktop icons, all you need do is right-click the Desktop, click View and, from the resulting list, uncheck the Show Desktop Icons option. All your icons will now disappear, leaving you to admire your wallpaper. Don't worry, your icons haven't been lost forever — simply repeat the same process to make them reappear in exactly the same place.



Free up space on your hard disk with Disk Cleanup

When you first run Vista, the Sidebar appears by default down one side of the screen. The standard components of the Sidebar, commonly known as Gadgets, include a clock, calendar and RSS feed. However, you can replace these with other Gadgets available at no cost online. You'll need a broadband internet connection to take full advantage of the Sidebar, but once you've got it running the way you want, it's a great way to stay up to date.

Enhance Vista's performance

Regardless of the glitz and glamour of Vista, most users' top priority is to find out how to boost their PC's performance, especially if it's running on a PC that's a few years old. We will soon take you through the top six ways to give Vista a shot in the arm, including how to calm down the processor-hogging special effects, reduce background activity and employ Readyboost to quickly and cheaply increase the amount of memory available. You'll also find out how to prevent unwanted applications from hogging system resources using Vista's built-in Msconfig application.

There are plenty of other ways you can give Vista a performance boost, including making sure your hard disk is healthy and running efficiently. To do this, first click on the Start button, type 'Disk Cleanup' and press Enter. Vista will prompt you to select a

Boost mobile performance

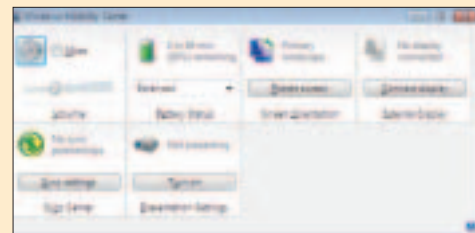
If you're running Vista on a laptop, you'll want to make sure it's not draining power unnecessarily when away from the mains.

The Vista Mobility Center helps out here by providing easy access to a variety of customisable power-saving options. Since it's only pertinent to mobile devices such as laptops, you won't be able to access this feature on a desktop PC running Vista.

There are three preset power plans to choose from (Balanced, Power Saver and High Performance), but the Mobility Center also lets you tweak the individual settings of each.

You'll also be able to find out exactly what percentage of your battery's power remains and roughly how long you have before you'll need to make a dash for a wall socket.

Power plans can be changed manually, but Vista helps out by detecting when you unplug the mains adapter and will automatically switch to a mobile plan to save power.



The Mobility Center includes laptop power-saving tools